WorkNest Setup Guide

How to get your own copy of WorkNest running on your computer, with your own database, email, file uploads and Google sign-in.

What you'll set up

Service	What it's for	Required?
MongoDB Atlas	The database: users, jobs, applications	**Yes**
Brevo	Sending verification and password-reset emails	No: codes print in the server terminal instead
Cloudinary	Uploading CVs and client logos	No: everything else still works
Google Cloud	The “Continue with Google” button	No: email and password login still works

Step 1: Install the tools

• **Node.js 20 or newer**: https://nodejs.org

• **Git**: https://git-scm.com

• **VS Code**: https://code.visualstudio.com

Step 2: Fork the two repos

On GitHub, open each repo and click **Fork**. This gives you your own copy you can push to.

• Frontend: `https://github.com/emmy497/WorkNestFront`

• Server: `https://github.com/emmy497/WorkNestBack`

Create your accounts (all free)

MongoDB Atlas (database): required

1. Sign up at https://www.mongodb.com/cloud/atlas and create a free **M0** cluster.

2. Database Access → **Add New Database User**. Choose a username and password and write them down.

3. Network Access → **Add IP Address** → **Allow access from anywhere** (`0.0.0.0/0`).

4. Connect → **Drivers** → copy the connection string.

5. Replace `<password>` with your database user's password, and add `worknest` as the database name before the `?`:

```
mongodb+srv://user:pass@cluster0.xxxxx.mongodb.net/worknest?retryWrites=true&w=majority
```

This goes in `MONGO_URI`.

Brevo (emails): optional

1. Sign up at https://www.brevo.com.

2. SMTP & API → **API Keys** → **Generate a new API key**. Copy it into `BREVO_API_KEY`.

3. Senders, Domains & Dedicated IPs → **Senders** → **Add a sender** with your own email address, then click the confirmation link Brevo emails you. Put that address in `BREVO_SENDER_EMAIL`.

Important: if the sender isn't verified, Brevo silently rejects every email.

Cloudinary (uploads): optional

1. Sign up at https://cloudinary.com.

2. Your **Dashboard** shows the **Cloud name**, **API Key** and **API Secret**. Copy them into `CLOUDINARY_CLOUD_NAME`, `CLOUDINARY_API_KEY` and `CLOUDINARY_API_SECRET`.

Google sign-in: optional

1. Go to https://console.cloud.google.com and create a project called `WorkNest`.

2. APIs & Services → **OAuth consent screen**: choose **External**, fill in the app name and emails, and add yourself under **Test users**.

3. Credentials → **Create Credentials** → **OAuth client ID** → **Web application**.

4. Under **Authorized JavaScript origins**, add `http://localhost:5173`. No redirect URIs are needed.

5. Copy the **Client ID**. It goes in **both** `.env` files.

Run the project

Step 3: Set up the server

```
git clone https://github.com/<your-username>/WorkNestBack.git server
cd server
npm install
```

Copy `.env.example` to a new file called `.env` and fill it in:

```
PORT=5000
CLIENT_ORIGIN=http://localhost:5173
MONGO_URI=<from Atlas>
JWT_SECRET=<see below>
JWT_EXPIRES_IN=7d
GOOGLE_CLIENT_ID=<from Google, or leave blank>
BREVO_API_KEY=<or leave blank>
BREVO_SENDER_EMAIL=<your verified sender, or leave blank>
BREVO_SENDER_NAME=WorkNest
CLOUDINARY_CLOUD_NAME=<or leave blank>
CLOUDINARY_API_KEY=<or leave blank>
CLOUDINARY_API_SECRET=<or leave blank>
```

Generate your `JWT_SECRET` with this command and paste the output:

```
node -e "console.log(require('crypto').randomBytes(48).toString('hex'))"
```

Fill your empty database with sample jobs and companies, then start the server:

```
npm run seed
npm run dev
```

Check: open `http://localhost:5000/api/health`. It shows `{"status":"ok"}`.

Step 4: Set up the frontend

Open a **second terminal**. Leave the server running in the first one.

```
git clone https://github.com/<your-username>/WorkNestFront.git worknest
cd worknest
npm install
```

Copy `.env.example` to `.env`:

```
VITE_API_URL=http://localhost:5000/api
VITE_GOOGLE_CLIENT_ID=<same Client ID as the server, or leave blank>
```

```
npm run dev
```

Check: open `http://localhost:5173`. The WorkNest home page loads.

Step 5: Make yourself an admin

1. Sign up in the app and verify your email. Without Brevo, the code is printed in the **server** terminal, for example `[dev] verify-email code for you@mail.com: 123456`.

2. In the server folder, run `npm run make-admin you@mail.com`.

3. Log out and log back in. You can now open `/admin`.

If something goes wrong

Problem	Fix
`MongoServerSelectionError`	In Atlas, Network Access must allow `0.0.0.0/0`, and the password in `MONGO_URI` must be correct.
`bad auth : authentication failed`	You used your Atlas login password. `MONGO_URI` needs the **database user** password.
Password has `@` or `#` in it	Special characters must be URL-encoded in `MONGO_URI` (`@` becomes `%40`). Easier: choose a password with only letters and numbers.
No emails arrive	Your Brevo sender isn't verified. Also check your spam folder.
“Network Error” toasts in the app	The server isn't running, or `VITE_API_URL` is wrong.
Changed `.env` but nothing happened	Stop and restart both servers. `.env` is only read when they start.
404 errors on admin pages	The server is running old code. Use `npm run dev`, not `npm start`.
Can't open `/admin`	Run `npm run make-admin` with your email, then log out and back in.
Google: `origin_mismatch`	Add `http://localhost:5173` to Authorized JavaScript origins. It can take a few minutes to apply.
Google: `access_denied`	Add your Google account under **Test users** on the consent screen.

Keep your keys secret

• Never commit your `.env` files. Both repos already list `.env` in `.gitignore`, so don't remove it.

• Never paste your API keys or `MONGO_URI` into a chat, screenshot or GitHub issue.